Which tag should a Thai 2D indie studio pair with its next Steam game?

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1 The decision

Which second tag the studio builds and markets its next 2D game around. Owner: game director, before the concept brief. If a partner passed the rule, the brief would commit to it; as none did, the studio tests two first.

2 Why a network

A tag count cannot say which tags travel with 2D, which pairings are crowded, or which partner sits in another genre neighbourhood and so reaches a second audience. Those are pairwise relations.

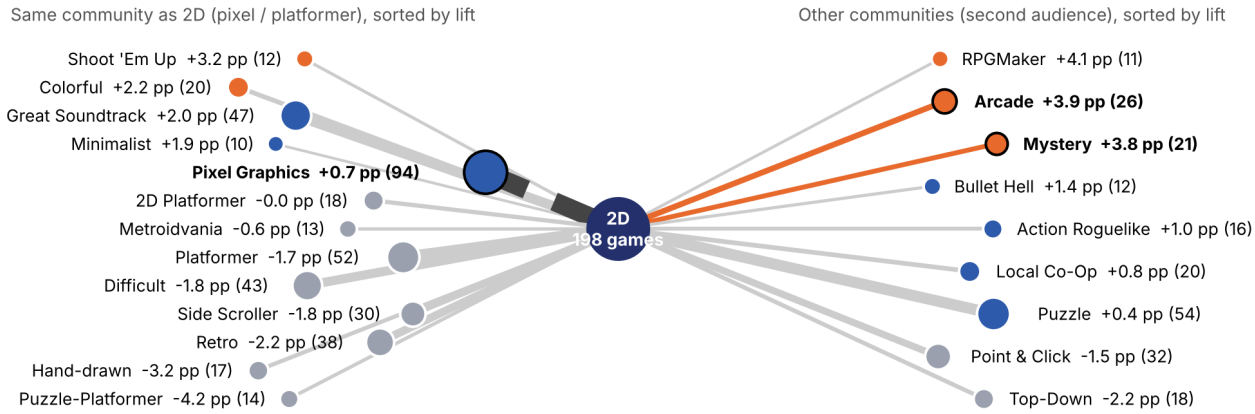
3 Data

Source	SteamSpy public API (tag, appdetails); Steam appreviews API as a check
Method	Python requests, 1.1 s delay; random 600 (seed 7202) of 6,287 Indie games with ≥500 reviews; 15 Oct 2026
Legal	Public API, no key; robots.txt Allow: /; game aggregates only, no user data; raw pulls not redistributed
Volume	592 games kept (≥5 tags); median 1,585 reviews, 85.9% positive
Bias	Survivors only (≥500 reviews): failed games invisible; player-voted tags, so synonyms co-exist
Check	Steam's own review share, 30 games: ρ 0.99 (median gap 0.4 pp), so one source suffices

4 Graph construction

Node / edge	Tag; edge = both in a game's top-15 voted tags
Weight	NPMI, not raw count: raw ranks 2D–Pixel Graphics first (94 games); NPMI puts synonyms first (Rogue-like–Rogue-lite 0.84)
Window	Top-15 tags; top-10 and top-20 swept
Pruning	Seed Indie excluded (77% of games); generic ≥40% dropped (Singleplayer, Adventure, Action); ≥10 games; NPMI ≥0.10
Size	157 nodes, 2,342 edges (from 6,830 pairs); figure shows 2D's 22 partners
Rule	Set before results: ≥10 shared games, top lift in median positive share vs 2D-only, #1 in ≥60% of 500 bootstraps

5 The picture



2D's ego network. Closer = higher NPMI; width = shared games; label = review lift vs 2D-only games (n). Left = same community; dashed = most crowded; orange = test candidates.

6 Findings

- **The obvious partner is crowded and adds nothing.** Pixel Graphics is on 94 of 198 2D games (47%), 2D's strongest tie (NPMI 0.43), yet lifts positive reviews by only +0.7 pp (p 0.57); 8 of 13 same-community partners score below 2D-only games.
- **The upside sits in other communities.** The top three lifts all reach outside 2D's neighbourhood: RPGMaker +4.1 pp (11 games), Arcade +3.9 pp (26, p 0.11), Mystery +3.8 pp (21, p 0.11).
- **No partner passes the rule.** RPGMaker is first in only 2 of 9 window × cutoff specs; the bootstrap leader holds #1 in just 13% (Arcade) and 12% (RPGMaker) of 500 resamples, far below 60%.

7 Recommended action

- **By 23 Oct:** game director drops Pixel Graphics as the positioning claim (art style only) and writes two one-page concepts: 2D + Arcade, 2D + Mystery.
- **30 Oct–13 Nov:** run both as ad variants to one Steam 'coming soon' page, with 2D + Pixel Graphics as control; keep the variant only if it gets ≥20% more wishlists per 1,000 impressions.
- **By 20 Nov:** re-run the notebook on all 6,287 games (not 600) with synonym tags merged; commit to a partner only if it then passes the 60% bar.

8 What would change my mind

Pairs that review well do not cause good reviews: strong studios may choose them, and only survivors are visible. If the full-pool re-run puts another partner above 60%, or neither variant beats control, I would brief a plain 2D game.